challenge was suddenly made alarming for Salim by the support of two powerful noblemen. Mirza Aziz Koka, Khusrau's father-in-law, was already present at court, long rehabilitated since his wanderings in Mecca. Now, in August 1605, Raja Man Singh arrived at court from his subah in Bengal and Akbar raised his mansab to 7,000, previously reserved only for princes of the royal blood. For a while, Man Singh was the highest mansabdar of the land, Hindu or Muslim. His grandson Maha Singh had also been raised to a mansab of 2,000. Man Singh was the maternal uncle of Khusrau and now the prince had the backing of the two most powerful and influential noblemen of the empire. The fifty-five-year-old Man Singh, barrel-shaped and eternal like the forbidding stone fortresses he liked to build, had earned for himself something of a fearsome reputation. All the mansabdars of the empire used amils, officers who were appointed to collect revenue on their behalf from their jagirs. Man Singh, it was said, almost never had to remove or transfer an amil but if anyone happened to complain about one of his officers, the 'poor fellow's house was given to plunder and taken over and with his neck tied he was thrown over the Rohtas Kalan fort. The transfer of the amils was the termination of their life and wealth.'

Even though the raja had spent decades away from the court, his informers would have kept him updated about the unravelling relationship between Akbar and Salim, and he would have been confident of the Padshah's support for Khusrau as his heir. The raja now tried to have Salim removed from the court by suggesting to Akbar that he be appointed to take over as Subedar of Bengal. But Salim, long accustomed to playing these deadly games at court, refused to move and leave the field open for Khusrau.

These simmering tensions were suddenly exposed in all their raw violence, aberrantly, during an elephant fight. Akbar had arranged for a fight between Chanchal, Ibrahim Adil Shah II's elephant newly arrived from the Deccan, and Giranbar, Salim's elephant. Salim and Khusrau were watching the fight seated on their horses while Akbar was looking down from the jharoka window, young Khurram seated next to him. While the two animals were crashing into each other and raising fine yellow dust, the servants of Salim and Khusrau got into a bitter fight, and 'both overstepped the bounds of courtesy'. A group of Salim's unruly servants threw stones at the imperial elephant-keepers, striking one of them on the forehead and wounding him. Akbar was furious at the behaviour of his heirs, no doubt